急がば回れ

RONIN

The free guide

SUPPLE-MENT TRUTH

What works.
What's a waste of money.

Worth it	6 supplements
Worth it if	8 supplements
Leave it	12 supplements

When in a hurry,
take the long way around.

浪人

Read this first

95 / 5

Training, food and sleep are 95% of your results. Supplements are the last 5%. This guide is about spending that 5% well.

The supplement industry sells hope by the tub. Most of what's on the shelf has never been shown to do what the label suggests. A handful of products are backed by solid research. Here's which is which.

Worth it	Proven, cheap, useful for almost anyone who trains.
Worth it if	Useful in specific situations. Check if that's you.
Leave it	Doesn't work, or works only on paper. Keep your money.

Evidence

- ●●● Strong: many good studies agree
- ●●○ Good: consistent, but less research
- ●○○ Mixed: some studies yes, some no

Read this first

THREE RULES

1 **Food first**

A supplement fills a gap. If there's no gap, there's nothing to fill.

2 **One at a time**

Add one new product, give it a few weeks, then judge. Start five at once and you'll never know what worked.

3 **Buy tested**

Supplements aren't approved before they're sold. Look for an NSF Certified for Sport or Informed Sport seal: it means a lab checked the label and checked for banned substances.

> **Not medical advice**
>
> Talk to a doctor before starting anything if you take medication, have a health condition, or are pregnant.

WORTH IT

Creatine monohydrate

3–5 g daily

●●● Strong evidence

More strength, more reps, more muscle over time. The most researched supplement in sports nutrition, and safe for healthy adults long term.

How 5 g a day, every day, any time. No loading phase needed. Expect 1–2 lb of water in your muscles the first weeks. That's normal and it's what you want.

Protein powder

25–40 g a serving

●●● Strong evidence

Not magic, just protein that's easy to drink. It helps you hit your daily target, which is what actually builds muscle.

How Whey after training or whenever you're short on protein. Lactose trouble: whey isolate or a pea and rice blend. Casein before bed if dinner was light.

Caffeine

100–300 mg

●●● Strong evidence

Stronger, longer, more focused sessions. One of the few pre-workout ingredients with solid proof behind it.

How 30–60 minutes before training. Coffee works. Stay under 400 mg a day, and no caffeine 8–10 hours before bed.

Omega-3 fish oil

1–2 g EPA + DHA

●●○ Good evidence

Supports heart health and lowers triglycerides. May ease joint soreness under heavy training.

How With a meal that contains fat. Read the label: count EPA plus DHA, not “1,000 mg fish oil”. Eat fatty fish twice a week? You can skip it.

Vitamin D3

1,000–2,000 IU

●●○ Good evidence

Bones, immune system, muscle function. Most people who train indoors and live far from the equator run low, especially in winter.

How Daily with your fattiest meal. Ideally test your blood level first. Don’t go above 4,000 IU a day without a doctor.

Psyllium husk

5–10 g daily

●●○ Good evidence

Pure fiber. Keeps digestion regular, keeps you full on a cut, and lowers LDL cholesterol.

How Start with 3–5 g in a full glass of water and build up. Drink it fast, it thickens. Take it 2 hours apart from any medication.

WORTH IT IF

Magnesium glycinate

200–350 mg

●●○ Good evidence

Muscle and nerve function. Some people sleep better on it, especially if the diet is low in greens, nuts and seeds.

How In the evening. Glycinate is gentle on the stomach; oxide mostly isn't.

Electrolytes

300–600 mg sodium/h

●●○ Good evidence

Replace what you sweat out. Fewer cramps, better performance in long or hot sessions.

How During long cardio, fight training or a hot gym. A pinch of salt in your water does the same job for cents.

Beta-alanine

3.2–6.4 g daily

●●○ Good evidence

Helps in hard efforts that last 1 to 4 minutes: intervals, rounds of sparring, high-rep sets.

How Split into 2–3 doses with meals. Takes about 4 weeks to build up. The tingling skin is harmless.

Citrulline malate

6–8 g

●○○ Mixed evidence

Might give you a few more reps and a bigger pump. Nice to have, never necessary.

How 45–60 minutes before training. Skip any product that underdoses it.

Melatonin

0.5–1 mg

●●○ Good evidence

Resets your body clock after travel or a shifted schedule. Not a nightly sleeping pill.

How 30–60 minutes before your new bedtime, for a few days. Many US products are 5–10 mg; far less usually works.

Ashwagandha

300–600 mg

●○○ Mixed evidence

Some evidence for lower stress, better sleep and small strength gains.

How Daily for a few weeks at a time, then a break. Not for pregnancy or thyroid conditions. Rare liver issues are reported; talk to a doctor first.

Iron and vitamin B12

Only if low

●●● Strong evidence

Fixes fatigue and poor endurance when you're actually deficient. B12 is essential if you eat no animal products.

How Get a blood test first. Too much iron is harmful, so never take it on a hunch.

Multivitamin

1 a day

●○○ Mixed evidence

Cheap insurance during a hard cut or on a narrow diet. Doesn't replace food.

How With breakfast. A basic one is enough; mega-doses are just expensive urine.

LEAVE IT

~~BCAAs~~

Sold for muscle growth and recovery.

Zero extra benefit if you eat enough protein. Three amino acids out of the nine your body needs.

~~EAAs~~

Sold as the upgrade to BCAAs.

Better, but it's still just protein at a premium. Eat a meal or drink a shake.

~~Glutamine~~

Sold for recovery and growth.

No muscle or strength benefit in healthy lifters who eat their protein.

~~Testosterone boosters~~

Tribulus, fenugreek, D-aspartic acid.

No meaningful rise in testosterone in healthy men. Sleep, food and training do more.

~~Fat burners~~

Promise to melt fat.

Mostly caffeine at ten times the price. Some ingredients can strain your heart or liver.

~~Mass gainers~~

Sold as size in a tub.

Sugar and powder. Blend 80 g oats, a banana, a scoop of whey, 400 ml whole milk and a tablespoon of peanut butter: about 850 calories and 50 g protein.

~~HMB~~

Sold to stop muscle breakdown.

Maybe a small effect in total beginners. Nothing for anyone who already trains and eats protein.

~~ZMA~~

Sold for testosterone and sleep.

Only helps if you’re actually low in zinc or magnesium. Doesn’t raise testosterone.

~~Diet pills~~

CLA, raspberry ketones, garcinia.

The fat-loss claims don’t hold up in research. Your calorie number does the work.

~~Detox teas and cleanses~~

Sold to flush toxins.

Mostly laxatives. Your liver and kidneys already detox you for free.

~~Collagen for muscle~~

Sold as a protein source.

Low in leucine, so it barely builds muscle. Count it toward joints if anything, not your protein.

~~L-arginine “NO” pills~~

Sold for the pump.

Poorly absorbed when you swallow it. Citrulline does the job better.

What I take

MY STACK

Breakfast	Creatine 5 g. Omega-3 with food. Vitamin D3 2,000 IU from October to April.
Mid-morning	Psyllium 5 g in a big glass of water.
Before training	Black coffee, 30–60 minutes out.
After training	Whey, only if I'm short on protein for the day.
Evening	Magnesium glycinate.
Fight blocks	Beta-alanine, when I'm doing a lot of rounds and intervals.

Cost: roughly the price of two takeout meals a month.

Shopping

HOW TO BUY

Creatine

Plain creatine monohydrate powder. Unflavored is fine. Skip “buffered”, HCl and anything in a fancy blend.

Protein

Check protein per scoop against calories per scoop. A good whey is around 80% protein: 24 g protein in 120 calories.

Fish oil

Add up EPA and DHA on the back label. That number, not the front of the bottle, is your dose.

Pre-workout

If you buy one, the dose of each ingredient must be printed. “Proprietary blend” means they hide it. Put it back.

Price

Compare cost per serving, not per tub. Expensive rarely means better.

石の上にも三年

“Even a cold stone grows warm if you sit on it for three years.”

Ishi no ue ni mo san nen

No capsule replaces showing up. Supplements are the 5%. The other 95% is the system: training, food, sleep.

The system

Cycle I, Earth: Demon Back

Four weeks of training, cardio, a meal plan, a calorie calculator and sleep, in one PDF. $27.

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